

You said it...



we do cover BSD too. It's just that very few people write about it. If you (along with friends you know in the BSD community) can contribute articles on the subject, we could have a regular series on BSD in LFY and on LinuxForU.com too. By the way, the DVD this month contains the ISO image of the latest Free BSD 8.0 release. Hope you'll burn it to a DVD to install it, and then, perhaps, send us feedback on what you think about the new features from the land of BSD :-)

Maemo coverage

 I recently went through the Nokia Maemo website (maemo.nokia.com). Can you do a review of Maemo (and optionally the N900)? It appears to me to be one of the best demonstrations of the capabilities of Linux and other FOSS products such as Mozilla-based browsers, OpenGL, etc. Also, a primer on developing apps for Maemo would be a bonus.

—Saurav Sengupta, Chandigarh, saurav.public@gmail.com

ED: Well, you've seen the February 2010 cover already. Hope you like the coverage given to Maemo.

Online CAT

 Recently, the online CAT was in the news quite a lot. We use Moodle as a learning management system and specifically to conduct online exams. Initially, we too faced problems similar to what CAT faced. The cause of the problems was the simultaneous access by a large number of users distributed across the country.

We have an LVS with a back-up for load balancing. It connects to two Web servers (Apache), which in turn connect to a DB server (MySQL). We also have a storage

server in the system. All of them are interconnected through a high-speed LAN. Even though our hardware can handle a large number of simultaneous accesses, Moodle itself has limitations. Bandwidth constraints add to the problem. Any amount of server tuning and application tuning does not solve the problem.

I believe that the CAT online exam faced similar problems. We solved our problems by scheduling the exams such that not more than about 700 people took it at one time. Where the examinees are located far away, we set up local servers and synchronised with the master server, manually. Though the last step can be automated, I think some amount of manual intervention is healthy. We also created a large question bank where questions are picked up randomly, so that different groups got different question papers.

—Lalitha K Prasad, Head, Corporate Learning Centre, Tata Consultancy Services

ED: Thanks—this is very interesting feedback.

ERRATA January 2010

The word 'bootstrapping' that appeared on the cover of the last issue and in the section highlighting the contents on page 4 was incorrectly spelt as 'bootstraping'. We regret this error, and promise to take steps to avoid such silly mistakes.

Please send your comments or suggestions to:

The Editor

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